A Collaborative Game-Based Learning Project for Gender Equity Awareness

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Abstract:

Although gender equity has advanced in several areas of society, significant inequalities remain, particularly within STEM education and the professions. Vertical segregation continues to shape working life, with unequal access to senior positions for women and men. This study addresses that problem through *The Golden Thread*, an educational game developed to raise awareness of women's barriers and unequal pathways to senior positions. The study explores how participation in the game session may shape students' awareness and perceptions of gendered inequalities in career progression.

The Golden Thread was developed at King's College London in collaboration with the learning partner Dragon Learning. It was then integrated into a management course and tested with engineering students at Mid Sweden University. Inspired by the traditional Indian game *Snakes and Ladders*, the game combines a physical board format with digital instructions and was tested in an Active Learning Classroom (ALC). Kolb's experiential learning theory informed both the game design and its evaluation. The study is based on observations from two game sessions, as well as data from a semi-structured interview with the teacher, and the material was analysed using an inductive thematic approach.

The findings show that *The Golden Thread* encouraged active participation and discussion among the students. It generated energy, created openness among students, and fostered reflective dialogue about gender barriers, fairness, and discrimination. At the same time, the study identified areas for further refinement in both the game design and the facilitation of the learning session.

Keywords: Career strategies, Gender in games, Gender equity, Game-based learning, Experiential learning